Orlando Sentinel FOODIE AWARDS

Amy Drew Thompson | ORLANDO SENTINEL

Spongy-wonderful injera abounds at Nile Ethiopian on I-Drive. **ORLANDO SENTINEL FILE**

BEST AFRICAN
CRITIC'S CHOICE: NILE ETHIOPIAN CUISINE

I'm crossing my fingers, pre-results, that Nile Ethiopian takes the Readers' Picks crown this year so that together we can give it a double birthday present, because 2026 marks 20 years in business for this wonderful, colorful, humble and no-doubt flavorful slice of I-Drive's unbelievable, under-the-radar dining scene. Nile is a lasting pioneer among loads of smaller, less glitzy, family-run businesses in the tourist zone and I am grateful that both visitors and fervent locals have kept the injera bubbling at Abeba Gonetse's lovely little spot. Look for an official story later this year.

And while you're at it, look outside the theme park zone for additional options, like last year's winner: Yene Romay. And Ethiopian-Eritrean regular in this section, Selam.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Nile Ethiopian Cuisine, 7048 International Drive in Orlando, 407-354-0026; nileorlando.com
Runners-up:
- Selam Ethiopian & Eritrean Cuisine in Orlando
- Yene Romay Ethiopian Kitchen, food truck

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Boma — Flavors of Africa, 2901 Osceola Parkway in Lake Buena Vista
Runners-up:
- Nile Ethiopian Cuisine in Orlando
- Jiko — The Cooking Place in Lake Buena Vista

Menemen, a Turkish scrambled egg dish, is pictured atop a slice of fresh sourdough at Sourdough Bread House in Casselberry. **AMY DREW THOMPSON/ORLANDO SENTINEL**

BEST BREAKFAST
CRITIC'S CHOICE: SOURDOUGH BREAD HOUSE

I've been giving nods to Sourdough Bread House for years, but having dropped in to their new Casselberry digs recently, I think it's time for an upgrade. Open daily from 7 a.m. to 2:30 p.m., they offer an absolutely gorgeous Turkish breakfast with cheeses, fruits, nuts, spreads and more (not to mention the basket of warm, sliced, fresh-baked bread that comes on the side). To perfect it, someone's got to order the mesemen, a scrambled egg dish loaded with color, from the beautiful yolks to the colorful tomatoes and peppers. The thin-sliced onions, too, are a wonder. Aside from the Turkish-leaning goodies, of which there are plenty (tea and coffee, too!), there's lots of familiarity: avocado toast, waffles, pancakes, bacon/egg/cheese panini and more.

And then you can take home a massive, pillowy, crust-forward boule when you're through.

It's breakfast! It's a bakery! It's both! GO!

Meanwhile, out in Oviedo, the perfect, New York-style bacon, egg and cheese sandwich has landed. There's a Taylor ham/pork roll version for the Jersey-Philly crowd. And whoa: There's also an entire market of Italian specialties. If you're a northeasterner who loves Orlando weather but misses real-deal BECs, your search is over, friends. Throw your coats away forever.

Over at East End Market, between Papi's outstanding breakfast burritos, Hinckley's famous sandos and Winter Park Biscuit Co.'s popular plant-based biscuits, all bases are covered.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Sourdough Bread House, 5761 S. U.S. Highway 17 92 in Casselberry, 407-636-5204; sourdoughbreadhouse.com
Runners up:
- D'Amico & Sons Italian Market and Bakery in Oviedo
- East End Market in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Johnny's Diner, 3335 Curryford Road in Orlando, 407-868-8267; johnnysdiner.co
Runners-up:
- The Town House Restaurant in Oviedo
- Café Osceola in Orlando

Decisions, decisions: An array of goodies at the Buttermilk Bakery counter. **ORLANDO SENTINEL FILE**

BEST BAKERY
CRITIC'S CHOICE: BUTTERMILK BAKERY

I am so wild about all three of these bakeries. And they're all so different, it almost just depends on what you're craving in the moment.

At Valhalla Bakery, it's more than just a plant-based diner's pastry playground, it's the home of the Death Bar, a dessert so decadent, desirable and dangerous that you'd walk directly into your certain demise just to experience the fudgy power of it's blissful brownie-to-whipped-peanut-butter ratio. Yeah. Valhalla's a good name for this place.

At M'ama Napoli, it's all things Italian, from breads to bombolone, courtesy of its mom-and-pop team behind the counter and in the kitchen. And don't get me started on the sandwiches. They were, in fact, last year's top pick in the category.

At Buttermilk Bakery, where croissants shatter into flaky bits of heavenly snow and brioche doughnuts and homemade guava cheesecake pop tarts tempt, you can see what sweets and savories are available online for pre-order, same day (the menu drops at 8 a.m.) or walk in and roll the dice. The earlier you get there, the more variety you'll find. And wherever you're bringing them, I guarantee whoever's there will be happier when you show up.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Buttermilk Bakery, 1198 N. Orange Ave. in Orlando, 321-422-4015; buttermilk-bakery.com
Runners-up:
- M'ama Napoli Italian Bakery & Deli in Winter Park
- Valhalla Bakery in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Charlie's Bakery & Creamery, 3213 Curry Ford Road in Orlando, 407-898-9561; charliesbakery.com
Runners-up:
- The Glass Knife in Winter Park
- Buttermilk Bakery in Orlando

Briskets now has a dine-in spot in Chuluota, too. Go see them for award-winning plates and save room for those homemade desserts. **AMY DREW THOMPSON/ORLANDO SENTINEL**

BEST BARBECUE
CRITIC'S CHOICE: BRISKETS BBQ SHACK & GRILL

The quest goes on for tip-top barbecue in the metro, a tall order, because these three titans are tough to beat. For now, I'm sticking with these, which give Q fans options all across the metro.

First up, a big congrats to Briskets BBQ! Not only have they managed to hang onto their cute lil' shack in Oviedo following a bit of a struggle, they've expanded, too. A new Chuluota location has helped widen their Seminole County footprint, and their menu, which now offers country breakfasts and other new items along with their impressive roster of traditional meats, sides and homemade desserts. The footprint in Oviedo has changed a bit, but the quality Q they're slinging here hasn't.

Congrats, too, to Smokemade Meats + Eats, which landed a Michelin recommendation in 2025, but the city's known that honor was well deserved for quite some time. Mohawk, meanwhile, has cultivated enough of a following since their win last year to end up in the Readers' Choice finals, too. This mobile outfit's star is rising. I can't say I'm surprised.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Briskets BBQ Shack & Grill, 298 Geneva Drive in Oviedo, 407-542-3201 or Barbecue & Country Kitchen, 640 S. County Road 419 in Chuluota, 407-542-7935; brisketsbbq.com
Runners-up:
- Mohawk Smokehouse, pop-up
- Smokemade Meats + Eats in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Willieboy's BBQ, food truck, willieboysbbq.com
Runners-up:
- Granny's Southern Smokehouse in St. Cloud
- Mohawk Smokehouse, pop-up

BEST BREWERY
CRITIC'S CHOICE: TEN10 BREWING

The space at Ten10 Brewing Company is as chill as they come. This place is music-centric, with live bands and fun, vinyl-based events that allow guests to bring in their favorite spins to play, and the food (housemade hot dogs, anyone?) is top notch, including a spent-grain pretzel and what I still believe is the best beer cheese in town — though I wouldn't be mad about doing an updated investigative piece about this at all.

Over at Tactical Brewing in Baldwin Park, not only are the beers incredibly good, but the food trucks they bring in for events like their weekly trivia night are top-of-the-line (sometimes even cutting-edge) and with an all-new flagship location set to open soon in Minneola, at Winter Garden's killer Crooked Can — where a Michelin-rated sushi bar, top-shelf oysters and more are steps away — you can't go wrong. That beautiful outdoor space beneath the trees at Plant Street Market makes it that much more special.

Michelle Wallace pours beer behind the bar at Ten10 Brewing Company in Orlando. The local citrus ale beer released is named "Orange County Reporter" and is named for the Sentinel's predecessor — Orlando's first newspaper. **STEPHEN M. DOWELL/ORLANDO SENTINEL**

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Ten10 Brewing, 1010 Virginia Drive in Orlando, 407-930-8993; ten10brewingcompany.com
Runners-up:
- Tactical Brewing in Orlando
- Crooked Can Brewing Company in Winter Garden

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Crooked Can Brewing Company, 426 W. Plant St. in Winter Garden, 407-395-9520; crookedcan.com
Runners-up:
- Ivanhoe Park Brewing Company in Orlando
- Tactical Brewing Co. in Orlando

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